

Ancient Free Gardeners of Scotland
Rose of England Lodge
Initiation Ritual in the Apprentice Degree
2020

Opening of the Lodge

The Worthy Master gives Three Knocks, Repeated by the Deputy Master.

Worthy Master: Worthy Deputy Master, what is our first duty?

Deputy Master: To see that none but Gardeners are present.

Worthy Master: Then I would thank you to ascertain that none, but such are in the room.

Deputy Master: Worthy Master, I believe all are correct.

Worthy Master: Worthy Officers and Brothers.

The Laws of our Order have once more called us together for the purpose of learning the condition of our sick and fully considering all matters pertaining to the Welfare of this Institution, whether concerning Member, Lodge, District, or the Society, which shall be brought forward in a lawful and proper manner.

These important duties, with your calm, candid, and impartial assistance, I hope and trust you will help me to perform.

I, therefore, declare this Lodge Duly Opened.

Deputy Master: So it is.

Chaplain Opens Bible - Old Testament at Genesis Chapter 1.

Business of the Lodge

Worthy Master Knocks Once (Not Repeated).

Worthy Master: Bro. Secretary may we have the Minutes from our Last Meeting.

Bro. Secretary reads Minutes.

Worthy Master: Brethren, you have all heard those Minutes, all those who deem them worthy of confirmation will signify in the manner usually observed amongst Free Gardeners

Worthy Master: To the contrary?

Worthy Master: I Declare those Minutes Confirmed

Bro. Conductor collects Minute Book from Secretary for WM to Sign.

Worthy Master: Bro. Secretary may we have the Apologies for this Meeting.

Bro. Secretary reads Apologies.

Worthy Master Knocks Once (Not Repeated) and Asks the Following Questions:

Worthy Master: Has any Brother anything to state for the good and welfare of this Lodge or the Order in General?

Question to be Closed by W.M. by Three Knocks, answered by the D.M.

Worthy Master: Are any of our Members sick, or in distress, or suffering any calamity?

If so, what is their condition? And how can we best assist them?

Question to be Closed by W.M. by Three Knocks, answered by the D.M.

Worthy Master: Has any Brother any charge, grievance or complaint to lay before this Lodge according to Rule?

Question to be Closed by W.M. by Three Knocks, answered by the D.M.

Worthy Master: Bro. Secretary do you have any other business.

Bro. Secretary deals with any other business.

Question to be Closed by W.M. by Three Knocks, answered by the D.M.

Worthy Master Knocks Once (Not Repeated) and Ask the Following Question:

Worthy Master: Has any Brother a friend to propose to become a Free Gardener?

Bro. Secretary Reads out Candidates names.

Question to be Closed by W.M. by Three Knocks, answered by the D.M.

Apprentice Degree

Worthy Master: Bro. Conductors you will Retire and Bring into the Lodge the Candidates.

Bro. Conductors Retire and Bring into the Lodge the Candidates and Seat Them.

Nominated Brother Stands in front of D.M. and Reads Introductory Address

Introductory Address to New Members

The Ancient Order of Free Gardeners is of Scottish Origin with the earliest record being a Minute of a Lodge of Free Gardeners in Haddington, East Lothian dated 16th August 1676.

The earliest Lodges were Operative, being made up of Gardeners employed in Large Estates and Country Houses. At that period Country Houses were particularly fashionable and both plants as well as Gardeners themselves were imported from the Continent.

Within the Lodge, Free Gardeners would look after the sick and needy, and also care for the welfare of a deceased members' family.

These early Operative Lodges gradually admitted into membership non-operative gardeners and the structure was similar to other Fraternal Organisations.

In the 19th Century membership expanded greatly, and thousands of Lodges were formed. These were the days prior to the Welfare State and the organization was very much a Friendly Society. These Friendly Societies flourished until 1946 when the Welfare State was created in the United Kingdom. Overnight Friendly Society's folded and by the Mid-Fifties Free Gardeners Lodge were all but extinct.

However, in 2002 a revival took place with the development and creation of a small number of Independent Lodges, out of this development Ayrshire Bluebell Lodge No.7 was Instituted on Thursday 20th November 2003, and that Lodge Instituted the 'Rose and Bluebell Lodge' on Saturday 24th August 2019 in Dalry, Ayrshire, Scotland and on the 29th August 2020. The Rose and Bluebell Lodge Instituted this Lodge, the 'Rose of England Lodge' in Stoneleigh Surrey.

It was agreed from the outset that the Ritual be read and not recited, this will ensure that all Brethren are equal, and none shall have any advantage over another.

You will now retire with the Bro. Conductors and on your re-entry, you will be Admitted to the Three Degrees of Free Gardenry namely – Apprentice, Journeyman and Master Gardener.

Bro. Conductors Retire with the Candidates.

Outside Tyler Knocks Once on the Door.

Inside Tyler Opens Door, Sees Bro. Conductors with Candidates, Closes Door.

Inside Tyler: Worthy Master a Brother with a friend/s for initiation, wishes entrance here.

Worthy Master: Admit him.

The Bro. Conductors enter and lead the Candidates in front of the Deputy Master

Bro. First Conductor: Worthy Deputy Master, here are friends who wish to become a partaker of the benefits arising

from a knowledge of the principles of Gardenry.

Deputy Master: Friends you have now entered the precincts of our Garden, and you will take notice that you will be required to observe three things.

First: That you must diligently study the principles of our Order that you must become proficient in the practice thereof. Second: That you must not, on pain of expulsion disclose any secret connected with the Order, by which you may give opportunity to evil disposed persons to impose upon and take advantage of our benevolent Institution.

Third: That you will at all times consider Brother Gardeners as persons bound to you by one common tie of true friendship, and that you will in no way act deceitfully toward them, but that you will visit them while sick, advise with and assist them in their hour of sorrow and distress, and like the good Samaritan, pour into their mental and bodily wounds that healing balm which springing from the principles of Gardenry, soothes and heals the cares and miseries inherent to this life's pilgrimage.

Are you prepared to do this?

Candidate/s: I Am.

Deputy Master: I now recommend you to our Worthy Master, Who will further instruct you in the principles of the Order. Bro. Conductors, you will conduct the candidate/s to his/their seat/s before our Worthy Master.

Bro. Conductors seat the Candidates.

Chaplain stands and Reads from Genesis Chapter 1 Verses 1-13.

1:1 In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth.

1:2 And the earth was without form, and void; and darkness was upon the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters.

1:3 And God said, Let there be light: and there was light.

1:4 And God saw the light, that it was good: and God divided the light from the darkness.

1:5 And God called the light Day, and the darkness he called Night. And the evening and the morning were the first day.

1:6 And God said, Let there be a firmament in the midst of the waters, and let it divide the waters from the waters.

1:7 And God made the firmament, and divided the waters which were under the firmament from the waters which were above the firmament: and it was so.

1:8 And God called the firmament Heaven. And the evening and the morning were the second day.

1:9 And God said, Let the waters under the heaven be gathered together unto one place, and let the dry land appear: and it was so.

1:10 And God called the dry land Earth; and the gathering together of the waters called he Seas: and God saw that it was good.

1:11 And God said, Let the earth bring forth grass, the herb yielding seed, and the fruit tree yielding fruit after his kind, whose seed is in itself, upon the earth: and it was so.

1:12 And the earth brought forth grass, and herb yielding seed after his kind, and the tree yielding fruit, whose seed was in itself, after his kind: and God saw that it was good.

1:13 And the evening and the morning were the third day.

Worthy Master then addresses them as follows:

Worthy Master: Respected Brothers, the principles and precepts of our Society teach us to unite together in the bond of brotherly affection for the purpose of promoting each other's temporal and moral welfare, and under all circumstances in life to be faithful to each other. We have, therefore individually bound ourselves in a most sacred covenant to keep the secrets of this order a mystery from the rest of the world, and we trust that no circumstance will ever induce you to violate the pledge you have thus voluntarily made: for should you prove a traitor to the Society, and bring dishonour upon this Institution, by betraying the trust we now repose in you, you would forfeit all

claim to our future confidence: it would render you a contemptible being, and unfit for any society. But if you conduct yourself with propriety and act in accordance with the rules and precepts of the Order, you will gain the esteem and affection of all your brethren. You will render yourself happy and useful in promoting the benevolent objects of this Institution, and become a blessing to the Community at large.

Our order may be called a social fraternity, an unlimited number of individuals mutually united together by virtue and affection in the social bonds of brotherhood. "Do unto others as you would wish that others should do unto you" It is our first and leading principle. To diffuse peace and happiness amongst each other and to disseminate the principles of charity and benevolence amongst mankind generally is our chief delight. This is our duty as united brethren to inform each other's minds, to assist each other in distress, to console and support each other in the hour of sickness and affliction, and to nourish and protect the destitute orphans, and dry up the tricking tear, and comfort the bereaved widows of our deceased brethren: and thus to teach the human mind the delightful exercise of the social principles of virtue by the practice of benevolence, affection and truth. Our Order has no religious or political association, it teaches no sectarian creed, it assumes no control over the religious tenants of the Christian faith, its rules and precepts are subservient to the established laws of our country, and it compels its members, under pain of expulsion, to act justly in their intercourse with the world and each other. We trust that the practice of these principles will acquire for the Order your esteem and affection, that in you will be found a worthy and faithful member, ready at all times to defend its principles. Thus, every sphere of life which you may have to pass, will be adorned with virtue, your integrity of conduct will secure the approbation of your brethren: and acquire universal esteem by disseminating the sacred principles of Friendship, Love and Truth.

Worthy Master: I will now entrust you with the Grip and Word of this Degree *If more than One Candidate* with the Assistance of the Deputy Master.

GRIP: Normal Handshake Three Times.

WORDS: Dig deep for Knowledge.

Candidates are Seated.

The Apprentice Lecture

Worthy Master: For what purpose are we assembled? *Deputy Master:* For pleasure, profit and instruction.

Worthy Master: In what doth our chief pleasures consist? *Deputy Master:* In the enjoyment of an unsullied conscience, in a faithful discharge of our duty, and in seeing each Brother happy.

Worthy Master: By what method do you insure to the Members profit from this Order?

Deputy Master: By providing while in health and strength for the urgent need and misfortunes of life.

Worthy Master: Why is our Lodge compared to a Garden? *Deputy Master:* As a Garden receives plants, shrubs and trees of various forms, natures and virtues, so doth our lodge receive men of various sentiments, dispositions and affections: and as a garden requires the hand of the cultivator to destroy all useless and pernicious weeds, and to train up with tender care the more valuable and useful plants, so doth the mind of man require aid from philosophy, precept and example, to root out and destroy all these unruly passions evil desires and degrading dispositions that debase the character of man, and to cherish with peculiar tenderness the more exalted sentiments of virtue, philanthropy and brotherly love. In these and many other particulars doth our Lodge resemble a garden?

We therefore call ourselves Gardeners. We must, therefore, ever remember that it is not merely the title, but the virtuous principles which adorn the conduct, that constitutes a true Gardener.

Worthy Master: Respected Brothers, I have now to introduce you into this community as an Apprentice Gardener. This post, humble though honourable, is the lowest in our profession: but by obedience and diligence by care and circumspection, by the cultivation of brotherly love, charity and benevolence you will soon attain the degree of a

Journeyman Gardener.

But you will have to dig deep for knowledge, to pull up and destroy the rank weeds of pride and self-conceit and walk in the paths of humility with a demeanor that becomes your profession. You will be under the Officers of the Garden, to whom you must owe submission and allegiance, and to whose reproof and correction you must submit with patience meekness and humility. You will have to pay due respect to the Officers of the Garden, if for nothing else, for the sake of their office, in as much as you may hereafter be called upon to fill the same yourself. Render therefore that respect and submission to others which the same situation you would wish to receive yourself. The mind of man is like a seed or bud, in which is concentrated a principle of vitality, capable of expanding into luxuriant growth, and bearing flowers and fruit: but then it must be cultivated. For no faculties of the mind are more generally neglected than those of observation and reflection: mankind sees and hears things without proper attention, without allowing them time to make an impression on their minds. *Worthy Master:* Hence the defection of their ideas, and the imperfection of their memories. Let your observations be close and attentive, so shall your minds become a rich treasury of ideas, a storehouse of the past, available at every future period of your life. If possible obtain an acquaintance with every tree, plant and flower within the range of your observation, their systematic arrangement. The beautiful relation that subsists between them, and the dependencies by which they are connected in one vast chain of being.--You will thus associate yourself with universal nature, and in your morning and evening walks the object of your acquaintance will greet you as friends, calling forth associations and pleasurable emotion unknown to minds less cultivate. Let no vicious propensity take possession of your mind: but let the broad and heaven-born principle of doing unto others as you would wish that they do unto you be the law of your minds, and the principles of your action. Be honest sober and industrious: be so for your own sake, and for the good of your country.

By this line of conduct your life will be virtuous and happy, you will secure "A WEALTH, that ne'er encumbers, nor to baser hands can be transferred: A HAPPINESS above the smiles and frowns of fate" "Then Onward! Onward! Let us press in paths of duty: VIRTUE is true happiness Excellence true beauty"

You will now retire with the Bro. Conductors and on your re-entry, you will be Admitted to the Degree of Journeyman.

Bro. Conductors Retire with the Candidates.

Ancient Free Gardeners of Scotland
Rose of England Lodge
Initiation Ritual in the Journeyman's Degree
2020

Opening of the Lodge

The Worthy Master gives Three Knocks, Repeated by the Deputy Master.

Worthy Master: Worthy Officers and Brothers we are once more met together for the purpose of giving the Journeyman's Degree: allow me therefore, to solicit your patient and undivided attention to the business of the day. Let no private or individual advantages prevent you from attending to the general good: and may order, peace, and unanimity prevail in this and all other meetings.

I declare this Lodge duly opened.

Three knocks

Deputy Master: So it is.

Bro. Conductors escort the Candidates to the door and gives Three Knocks.

Inside Tyler, opens Door: Who seeks entrance?

Outside Tyler: A Brother with Apprentices, who Wish to become Journeyman Gardeners.

Inside Tyler: Worthy Master, A Brother with Apprentices who wish to become Journeyman Gardeners seeks entrance.

Worthy Master: Admit them.

The Bro. Conductors enters and leads the Candidates in front of the Deputy Master, who asks Candidates for the Sign and Grip of the Apprentice Degree, if he finds him correct, the Deputy Master shall say:

Deputy Master: Worthy Master and Brothers, I find the Candidate/s has/have been properly instructed as an Apprentice Gardener.

Has he been obedient to the Laws and to the superior Officers, during his Apprentice probation?

Bro. Conductors: We believe he has.

Deputy Master: Has his moral conduct been in unison with his profession?

Bro. Conductors: We believe it has.

Deputy Master: Do you receive him as a Brother Gardener?

Bro. Conductors: We Do.

The Deputy Master then addresses the Candidate

Deputy Master: Worthy Brother, as a Gardener I would remind you of the White Rose, which is an emblem of Innocence and Virtue. The unsullied whiteness of its leaves represents the purity of the human mind when uncontaminated with vice. The fragrance it yields when its leaves are withered and dead, is an emblem of a life spent in piety and virtuous actions, which never fail to draw forth the admiration of surviving Friends and makes his memory dear to all who knew him. Never bring dishonour upon this Institution and that emblem will never bring dishonour upon you. May it be a true representation of your various virtues and may you enjoy a long and happy life. You have now become a Journeyman Gardener: may your future conduct be such as will raise the affectionate regard of your Brethren, and the approbation of all. I commend you to the injunctions' and further instructions of 'our Worthy Master' whose direction I trust you will be ever ready to follow, and whose commands you will be ever willing to obey.

Bro. Conductors place the Candidate/s before the Worthy Master.

Worthy Master: Will you promise in the presents of all here assembled, that you will never on any account whatsoever disclose any matters connected with the Journeyman Degree, that are to be kept secret: nor injure a

brother, nor suffer others to injure him, if within your power to prevent it?

Candidate: I will.

Worthy Master: Will you at all times as far as is consistent with your means, assist a Brother Journeyman in distress: and always strive to conduct yourself in such a manner, that you may by your practices bring honour to this Society?

Candidate: I will.

Worthy Master: Will you furthermore promise not to make, nor assist in making a Journeyman Gardener, in any way but that which is prescribed by the Laws of the Order?

Candidate: I will.

Chaplain stands and Reads from Genesis Chapter 2 Verses 15-17:

2:15. And the Lord God took the man, and put him into the Garden of Eden to dress it and to keep it.

2:16. And the Lord God commanded the man, saying, Of every tree of the garden thou mayest freely eat.

2:17. But of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, thou shalt not eat of it, for in the day that thou eatest thereof, thou shalt surely die.

Worthy Master: Worthy Brother you are now admitted a Journeyman Gardener. We rely with perfect confidence on sincerity of the promises you have made us this evening, and we doubt not that your future conduct will be such as will merit our approbation and esteem. You must now commence diligently to cultivate friendship amid affection for the Brethren of the Order. To sow the seeds of peace and concord, to promote order, harmony and good humour in all our meetings: and cherish a sincere attachment for every Brother in the profession. Carefully and diligently study the principles of the Order: they are founded on charity and benevolence. Be ever ready to assist the needy, to relieve those in distress, and to sympathise with the suffering. Let your public and private conduct be governed by the strict rules of justice and integrity. And let all your dealings with the world be in unison with that principle of moral rectitude which teaches us to do unto others as we would that they should do unto us. If possible, live in peace with all men, avoiding strife and quarrels of every description and promoting peace and good will with all mankind.

Pay due deference and respect to all those who by merit or fortune may be placed over you and act complacently to those who possess not the same advantages that you enjoy. Avoid intemperance and excesses of every description as irrational, injurious, and criminal. By Strict conformity to these precepts, you will bring honour and respect to yourself and your profession, promote your own comfort, and increase the happiness of those around you.

The Master then shall take him by the hand and say to those present:

Worthy Master: Brother Gardeners, I hereby present to you our newly Initiated Journeymen, commending them to your kindness and fostering care, and trusting that you will instruct them carefully and perfectly in the arts and mysteries of our profession.

Worthy Master: I will now entrust you with the Sigh, Grip and Word of this Degree *If more than One Candidate* with the Assistance of the Deputy Master.

SIGN: Tug Bottom of Sleeves, Left, Right, Left.

WORDS: Wisdom Strengthens

GRIP: Normal Handshake Three Times, but with the Thumbs Flat and Parallel.

You will now retire with the Bro. Conductors and on your re-entry, you will be Admitted to the Degree of Master Gardener.

Bro. Conductors Retire with the Candidates.

Ancient Free Gardeners of Scotland
Rose of England Lodge
Initiation Ritual in the Masters Degree
2020

Opening of the Lodge

The Worthy Master gives Three Knocks, Repeated by the Deputy Master.

Worthy Master: Worthy Deputy Master what is our first duty on opening the Masters Lodge?

Deputy Master: To see whether all present have received the Master's Degree!

Worthy Master: Then I would thank you to ascertain if all are correct.

Here the Deputy Master shall examine any Brother whom he may suspect of not having received the Master's Degree.

Deputy Master: Worthy Master, I believe all are correct.

Knock Once.

Worthy Master: Worthy Officers and Brothers, we are once more met together for the purpose of transacting the business of the Master's Lodge. Allow me to solicit your patient and undivided attention to all its interest: and let me hope that your deliberations will be conducted in the spirit of Order and impartiality, equity, and unanimity: and tend to the establishment of truth and justice, peace, and harmony.

I declare this Lodge duly Opened.

Knock Three Times.

Initiation

Bro. Conductors escort the Candidates to the door and gives Three Knocks.

Inside Tyler, opens Door: Who seeks entrance?

Outside Tyler: A Brother with Journeyman who wishes to become Master Gardeners.

Inside Tyler: Worthy Master a Brother with a Journeyman who wishes to become a Master Gardener seeks entrance.

Worthy Master: Admit them.

The Bro. Conductors enters and leads the Candidates in front of the Deputy Master, who asks Candidates for the Sign, Word, and Grip of the Journeyman Degree, if he finds him correct, the Deputy Master shall say:

Deputy Master: Do you desire to become a Master Gardener?

Candidate: I Do.

Deputy Master: Are you willing to give and receive instructions so far as your ability will enable you to do for the prosperity of this Order and the benefit of every Brother belonging thereto?

Candidate: I Am.

Deputy Master: Will you support and defend a Brother's character as far as you can, with justice perform this friendly office?

Candidate: I will.

Deputy Master: Will you seriously strive to avoid giving offence to all whom you are connected with, so that no discredit may be brought upon this Order thereby?

Candidate: I will.

Deputy Master: Are you willing to renew your former promise, adding thereto all that you have now promised to perform, including therein the Sign, Word and Grip of a Master Gardener?

Candidate: I Am.

Deputy Master: Will you promise in the presence of all here assembled that you never will on any account whatsoever, reveal to any but a Master Gardener any matter connected with this Degree that ought to be kept secret?

Candidate: I will.

Deputy Master: Will you furthermore promise to keep, maintain, support and defend the Laws of the Order as passed at this meeting in their full force and integrity, and never willfully break or evade them, or allow others to do so with impunity: but at all times endeavour to promise order and unanimity, and diffuse peace and concord throughout the Order.

Candidate: I will.

The Deputy Master shall then turn to the Master and Brother's present and says:

Deputy Master: Master and Brother's all, I find the Candidates duly qualified, and receive him in kindness and affection into our fraternity of Master Gardener's.

Bro. Conductors place the Candidate/s before the Worthy Master.

Bro First Conductor: Worthy Master I commend our Candidates to your further care and instructions.

Worthy Master: Dear Brother, you have now made a solemn and voluntary promise, and called all here to assemble and witness the same. Let us hope that your future life will be consistent with that promise and in obedience to the laws and principles of the Order. You will henceforth, through merit be able to fill the highest offices in the Order, but let not pride or restless ambition ever tempt you to aspire to offices for which you are not duly qualified. To be proud of virtue and ambitious of doing good from the right motives are always laudable; therefore, strive to excel in virtue. Let no opportunity of doing good escape unemployed. Be virtuous for your own sake, for the sake of your family, your friends, and your country. You may not have the means of extending your beneficence to deserving and less fortunate objects in a pecuniary way, but everyone has the opportunity of being kind---of rendering consolation and sympathy to the helpless and unfortunate. The Society into which you are now entered will afford you many opportunities of doing good and cultivating charity and benevolence. Remember that every act of charity is a double blessing---the giver is blessed in the act of giving and the receiver is blessed in receiving the manifestation of your kindness. You ought to consider every object of your kindness as having a claim on your benevolence, but especially those to whom you are this evening united in the bonds of fraternal affection. Let your conduct be always in obedience to the laws and principles of our Order, so shall your future life be long and happy. That such may be the case is the ardent wish of every truehearted Free Gardener.

Deputy Master: And so it is!

Worthy Master: Respected Brethren, as we bear the title of Master Gardener, it is our duty to explain in a brief manner wherein the term is applicable to our community. In the first place the whole world may with propriety be termed a garden set apart for the production and cultivation of a great variety of trees, shrubs, plants and flowers. When they are first raised from the seed, they are attended for a few years until they are arrived at a proper size and strength to be engrafted. The hand of a skilled Gardener is then required to place in those stocks such shoots from other trees as are most pleasing both to the eye and taste of the owner, thereby making a grateful return for the labour that has been bestowed upon them. Every man in the garden of this world bears a strong resemblance to one of these trees. He is first raised from the seed of nature and afterwards trained up with tender care until the buds of reason begin to break forth in his mind, at which time the shoots of wisdom and virtue are engrafted into his heart by Masters appointed for that purpose, who with anxious solitude strive to guard him until the shoots are properly incorporated with the stock and become a part of the same individual tree and fit to be transplanted to another situation where it will yield abundant stores of lovely and delicious fruit, and at the same time, give both pleasure and satisfaction to the proprietor. In the next place, our Lodges bear a striking resemblance to particular or select plots of fertile ground, which are planted with the most valuable trees and intend to grow in close compact or

near to each other's mutual support, one part shielding the other from the rude piercing blasts of the North and the other from the scorching rays of the meridian sun: thus, without sustaining any injury themselves they become each other's safeguard and support.

From this we may learn the benefit derived from a mutual union with each other, and for this purpose we form ourselves in select societies, to be enabled thereby to shield each other from the piercing storms of adversity, and to mitigate those woes that are in a greater or less degree, the lot of every human being.

Our lodges are like small parts of a garden, or fertile plots of ground, set apart for the culture of such trees or individuals as shall by the choice of our hearts be selected to grow through life in fellowship and union with us, for the purpose of shielding each other from distress, and to heal those hearts that are rent by mental anguish, and to pour into the woe-worn breast the healing balm of consolation. If the virtues that are cherished, their branches will extend to all around us, laden with lovely blossoms, and their fruit will sustain our fainting spirits. In the third point of view, every intelligent being may be compared to a garden; and its desires and affections with all its passions and prejudices, may be likened to the different plants and Weeds that are cultivated or spontaneously spring up in the garden around us; and as it is impossible to keep a garden entirely free from useless and pernicious weeds.

Worthy Master: So, it is almost impossible to keep the heart of man entirely free from those degrading desires and evil passions with which it is apt to overrun.

But as it is the practical Gardener's duty to root up and destroy all useless weeds that impoverish the soil, and retard the growth and prosperity of the ripening fruit, so it is our duty to secure the heart, by freeing it from all enchased desires and evil passions that would overrun and choke the seed of virtue, and make our hearts a barren and fruitful wilderness.

I will now entrust you with the Sigh, Grip and Word of this Degree *If more than One Candidate* with the Assistance of the Deputy Master.

SIGN: O Word (Olive) Similar to OK Sign.

GRIP: Handshake with Index Finger up Sleeve

WORD: Knowledge Enriches

Candidates are Invested with Apron and presented with Diploma.

Free Gardeners Lecture

Gentlemen can I add to the foregoing ritual that the central idea of Free Gardenry was based on images of gardening in the Old Testament with occasional references in the New.

Gardenry may be defined as an art of disposing the earth in such a manner as to produce whatever vegetables and fruits we desire.

Free Gardenry is the applying of the cultivation of the ground and its productions, as symbols of the necessity of the cultivating the mind of intelligence and virtue.

So, the First or Apprentice Degree was based on the story of the Garden of Eden and Adam, who was the first gardener in which God described him as "the Great Gardener of the Universe".

When Adam fell from grace, he put on a apron, just as the Free Gardeners wore one and had to go forth into the world and battle with weeds, briars and thorns, the effects of sin.

The Second or Journeyman's' Degree, related to Noah, the gardener who planted a vineyard after the flood. It also speaks of the Four Rivers flowing out of the Garden, Pison, Gihon, Hiddekel (now called the Tigris) and the Euphrates.

The Third or Master's Degree is about Solomon, described as a gardener, presumably on account of the imagery in the Song of Solomon.

Other Biblical references are used to gardens such as Gethsemane, and a number of trees and plants mentioned in the Bible were given significance, especially the Olive, a Sign of Peace!

That brings me to the Apron, the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners wore Long Aprons to their feet but latterly the style adopted into a more formal type as you can see today.

Various signs and symbols are evident on the Apron, printed around them are notably the letters P-G-H-E the initials of the Four Rivers.... And locked around Triangles containing the Letters of the First Three Biblical characters Adam, Noah and Solomon.

The "O" in the center is unclear, but Olive could be relevant in this case.

On the Sash in a Triangle Three "S's" can be noted these have been interpreted as Sythe, Syckle and Spade but figuratively as Secrecy, Solemnity and Service.

Closing the Master's Lodge

Worthy Master: Brothers, be upstanding, and assist us in Closing the Lodge.

Worthy Deputy, what demands our next care?

Deputy Master: To close the Lodge in peace, harmony, and friendship.

Worthy Master: Worthy Officers and Brothers, I thank you for your kind support this evening and for the attention you have paid to the interests of this institution, I trust a kind providence will enable us to meet again from time to time to forward our philanthropic and human objects. In the meantime, let me admonish you to cherish Brotherly love and kindly feelings one toward another, peace with your own conscience and all mankind, at the same time cultivating habits of industry and frugality, integrity sobriety and every virtue that can add lustre to the human character. I declare this Lodge duly Closed.

Knocks Three Times

Deputy Master: So it is.

Knocks Three Times

Chaplain Closes Bible.

Advanced Order of Free Gardeners Initiation Ritual

1878

Opening

R. W. M.: Officers, take your stations. Inner Guard, secure the Western gate against intrusion.

Senior Steward, ascertain if all present are qualified to remain within our inclosure.

The S. S. will perform this duty, and reports as follows:

S. S.: R. W. M., I have examined each one separately, and all are qualified to remain.

The R. W. M. then calls up the Officers of the Lodge.

R. W. M.: Senior Warden, what are your duties in this inclosure?

S. W.: To preside in the west, and assist you in opening and closing our labors here.

R. W. M.: Junior Warden, your duties?

J. W.: To preside in the South; assist in maintaining order, so that our meetings will be profitable to all.

R. W. M.: Deputy Master, what are your duties?

D. M.: To sit at your left hand; assisting you in the performance of your duties; and to officiate for you in your absence.

R. W. M.: Senior Steward, what are your duties?

S. S.: To examine the Brethren at the opening of our meetings; to conduct candidates at their initiation; and to see that members, who enter our inclosure, are properly clothed, and give the signs correctly.

R. W. M.: Junior Steward, what are your duties?

J. S.: To assist the S. S. in the performance of his duties; and to officiate for him in his absence.

R. W. M.: Secretary, what are the duties of your office?

S.: It is my duty to keep a correct and impartial account of the proceedings of our meetings, receive all moneys due from members, and pay the same to the Treasurer.

R. W. M.: Inner Guard, what are your duties?

I. G.: To guard the inner gate; allow none to enter without the proper signals; nor during the initiation of a candidate; or the opening and closing of our meetings.

R. W. M.: Outside Guard, what are your duties?

O. G.: To guard the outer gate against unworthy persons; and to make visitors and candidates welcome while waiting admission.

The R. W. M., then calls up the members.

R. W. M.: The members will please sing our opening ode

Opening Ode

(Air – "Bonnie Doom")

Again we meet, with mystic light

To guide us through the waste of care:

And may each brother feel 'tis right

A wearied brother's load to bear.

For as we toil up life's rough steep,

Some brother, faint, may need our care;

Then help him on, that he may reap

The fruits that only brothers share.

No nobler tie can e'er exist,
The world o'er than Gardenery;
Then closely to our hearts he pressed
Its motto: "Love and Harmony."
And while life's spring flows o'er the sand
Of God's immeasurable time,
Let not a helpless brother strand-
A brother's help is love sublime.

At the close of the singing, the Chaplain may read the following, or an extempore prayer. Just as it may suit the Officers and the members:

Kind Master, we humbly ask that Thy Spirit may reign amongst the brethren during our present meeting; that what may be said or done here, will be in accordance with thy Divine will and law so that love and harmony may prevail amongst us. We ask Thy kind blessing on our Order, and every member of it; teach them to seek after that which is good, and shun that, which in Thy sight, is evil. We ask this in the name of Thy Son, who left us the Commandment: "Love ye one another, as I have loved you." Amen.

R. W. M.: I now declare this meeting duly and legally opened for the transaction of such business as may be properly brought before it. We meet here for the purpose of assisting in the elevation of our member – morally and socially – and the relief of members in need.

Members are forbidden from introducing anything of a political or sectarian character, under the most severe penalty.

The R. W. M. then seats the Officers and members and proceeds, with the business of the evening.

Initiatory Ceremony

Preparation of a candidate – The Candidate is first blindfolded, and then pinioned, and led to the inner-door, when the J. S. gives ... raps.

I. G.: Right Worthy Master there is an alarm at the Western Gate.

R. W. M.: Ascertain the cause of the alarm, and be careful that you admit no unworthy person.

I. G.: The R. W. M. commands me to ascertain the cause of the alarm.

J. S.: It is a stranger from the outer world, who desires to mingle in fellowship with us.

I. G.: Is he duly qualified and prepared?

J. S.: He is ready for examination and willing to undergo the ordeal required of those who went before him.

When inside the inner door, the S. W. give the raps to call up the Lodge, and the S. S. advances toward the candidate.

S. S.: Stand! Stranger, what are your motives in seeking our fellowship: We demand an answer before you proceed further.

The members respond with the stamp of the foot: Yes; the answer!

Can.: My Motives are pure.

S. S.: 'Tis well.

Members answer: Yes; 'tis well.

S. S.: Stranger, have you considered the step you are this night about to take? Are you prepared to take the obligations peculiar to Free Gardeners. With this assurance that it will not come in conflict with any of the duties you owe to God, your country or yourself?

Candidate answers.

S. S.: Then follow me and fear not.

The candidate is then led slowly forward, and the S. S. continues while leading the procession.

S. S.: Stranger, you are now treading a path that many have sought to tread, but few have been chosen. It is the path that leads to the retreat of one whose words of experience and wisdom is of value to us all, and we hope they will prove such to you. Heed well his words and let them sink deep into your heart, for as a young candidate, they concern you especially. Stand! you are now within that retreat, and in the presence of our Venerable Brother Adam. The Candidate is restored to light, and Bro. A. assisted to his feet by the Ushers.

B. A.: Stranger, you are now in a place representing the Garden of Eden, – the first home of man – when God made man in his own image and placed him there. But even there, the tempter entered and man fell from the high estate in which he was placed; therefore, the Lord God drove him forth from the Garden of Eden to till the ground from whence he was taken. This was the punishment inflicted on our first parents for transgressing the law and is a fitting simile of the punishment meted out to those who violate our laws. Therefore, profit well by the lesson this affords, and see to it, that you break not the laws of your country or of this Society. I hope you have considered well the step you have this night taken. It is my duty to administer to you the obligation peculiar to this degree. The obligation by which we are all bound, and which we all cherish. Are you ready and willing to take that obligation?

Candidate answers.

B. A.: Then unloose his bonds. Stranger, you will kneel on your left knee, place your left hand on this open Bible, raise your right hand toward Heaven, and repeat after me the following solemn and binding obligation.

I, ..., of my own free will and accord, now, before God and this Lodge of Free Gardeners, being lawfully constituted under the name, style and title of ... Lodge, No. ... of A. O. F. G., located at I, now, in this lowly and humble position, do solemnly vow and declare, as I shall have to answer to God at the great day of judgment, that I will never make known to any one, not entitled to know the same; any of the signs passwords, grips, signals, tokens or tests, or any other secret or mystery of this order. I further promise, that I will always assist all poor and needy Brothers, as far as it is in my power so to do. And should I ever see a Brother in danger, I will consider it my duty to warn him of such danger, and do everything in my power to save him. Furthermore, do I promise, that I will never wrong a member of this order or see one wronged if in my power to prevent it. I further promise, that I will always so conduct myself, that no action of mine will ever bring disgrace on this order or any individual member of it. To all this, do I agree without the least hesitation, self-evasion or mental reservation whatever, coming under no less a penalty that that of being despised as a man, and disgraced as a brother. So help me God, to keep me steadfast in this, my 1st or apprentice obligation.

B. A.: Having taken the obligations of an Apprentice Gardener, I now welcome you as a Brother. My Brother, arise to your feet as a man and a Free Gardener. My Brother in requiring of you such an obligation as you have now taken, we have the fullest authority for so doing, as the following passage from the Holy Scriptures proves: "Thou shalt serve the Lord thy God; to Him shalt thou cleave, and swear by His name." History also teaches us that covenants and vows are as old as the world itself. Be faithful the, my Brother, to the vows you have this night taken. We expect you will cherish and maintain them through life, so that when your life on earth is ended, you will reap the rich reward due you, in the great hereafter to come. You have not yet finished your journey, but be of good cheer; follow your guide correctly, and you will reach the end in safety.

Ushers, you will continue to act as guide to our young Brother, who has yet more to learn before he can rank as an Apprentice.

The Candidate is then pinioned and hoodwinked.

Ode

You are welcome, Pilgrim, here
With its love's cares to bear
On to life's end;
Long may you live to view
The labor of brothers true
We ask a brother's help from you
And on it depend.
Our secrets well protect
When you're a Gardener decked;
Through life's rough patch
Let peace your motto be:
Love, Truth and Harmony
The emblems of Gardenery,
Crowned with a wreath!

S. S.: Brother, you are now within the mystic square, and in the presence of our Right Worthy Master.

R. W. M.: Has the young Brother taken our obligations in the silent and solemn retreat of our venerable Brother Adam?

S. S.: He has, Right Worthy Master, and is here with the hearty recommendation of our V. B. A.

R. W. M.: 'Tis well.

Brothers respond: 'Tis well.

R. W. M.: S. S., restore the Brother to Light and Freedom.

You are now within our Mystic Square, where none are allowed to enter unless those who have first taken upon themselves the obligations peculiar to our degree. Brother, *stepping forward and taking the Candidate by the hand* I now welcome you within the Square, that has never been broken by any good Free Gardener, and we hope it will never be broken by you.

There are certain words, signals and signs, which it will be necessary for you to know so as to enable you to correctly enter a working Lodge of the Apprentice Degree. When you enter the first ante-room, you will advance to the door and give ... raps, this will be answered from within, and the officer there will open the wicket, when you will give him the word ...; this will admit you to the inner-room, where you will clothe yourself according to your rank, and advance to the inner-door and give ... raps, this will also be answered from within, and the officer in charge there will open the wicket, when you will give him the word ..., this will admit you to the lodge room, when you will advance to the center of the floor, face the R. W. M., and salute him thus: If correct he will answer you, thus: ..., when you will turn half around and facing the S. W., who always sits opposite the R. W. M., salute him thus: ... if correct he will answer you thus: ..., when you will then take your seat among the members.

In this manner, and in this manner only, can you enter a regular lodge of Free Gardeners; be studious, therefore, in retaining these forms and signs on your mind, and be careful also, that you do not communicate them to any one not entitled to know the same.

You will now retire with our Senior Steward to the ante-room and be clothed with a proper regalia and return to the lodge room for further instructions.

The members will here remove their disguises, and the room be again arranged in proper order, with every officer and member in their proper place; the S. S. enters first, leaving the Brother to work his own way in through the door. They then advance together, salute the R. W. M., then turn and salute the S. W., then turn again to the R. W. M.

S. S.: Right Worthy Master, our Brother awaits the closing instructions in this degree.

The Right Worthy Master then instructs the Candidate in the "unwritten work" of the degree.

R. W. M.: My Brother, we hope you will make yourself proficient in the signs, words and grips, and that you will never improperly use them; and should you ever see any of those signs given by anyone, we expect you will consider it your duty to go at once to his assistance and render him such assistance as is in your power to do. You may, perhaps, have thought our ceremonies strange, and even frivolous in their character. But there are lessons to be learned from those ceremonies, if properly applied. You were blindfolded and pinioned, to represent the helpless condition of man whilst isolated from his fellow-man. In your journey to this chair, you met difficulties which would have made it impossible for you to have made your journey successfully, but for the kindly assistance of your conductors, teaching us that if we remain aloof from our fellow-men, - neither asking for or giving assistance, - this life will certainly be a failure. Be united, ever ready to extend a helping hand in the hour of distress, and having the assurance through such unity as here exists, that a helping hand is always ready among the Brothers to assist another in the time of need. For in this way, and this alone, can we assist in making this life a success. How pleasant, then, it will be for us all and when our life on earth is ended, we will leave this world with the pleasant satisfaction that it has been the better from us living in it. And that in leaving this world, and it may be, leave a dear wife and loving children behind, that we leave behind us those whose duty it is to care for those dear ones, in making their path through life more easier to travel. This assurance will smooth our pillows in the last hours of our lives, and make our departure from those dear ones easier to bear. You were then led within a solid square, in which you were surrounded by your Brothers on all sides.

In your position you could be seen by all, yet, you could not distinguish those who surrounded you.

This is emblematical of the All-Seeing Eye of God which is ever upon us. Although we cannot distinguish it, yet, rest assured, it is always there, watching our every action. It also reminds us of the solid unity of the members. It is truly styled the Mystic Square for no hard feeling can be nurtured or hard words spoken, or bad action done by one of its members, but is felt by all the body. Then, my Brother, rule your passions well; let none of these gain the mastery over you, and try to live a life of Love, Harmony and Peace.

Closing

R. W. M. calls up the Lodge.

R. W. M.: I. G., what is the last duty of your office?

I. G.: To remove the fastening of the inner gate, and let the brothers depart to their homes.

Closing Ode

Air "Auld Lang Syne."

Good night, good night, we part to meet

Prompt at our Master's call;

Long may we live in love to greet

Our faithful brother all.

And as we daily tend the vine,

Which God to us hath given:

May we receive His grace divine,

And meet at last in Heaven.

Chap.: Our Heavenly Master, we thank Thee for the privilege we have this night enjoyed. Bless the good work done here; lend Thy aid in spreading the good work our beloved Order has in view; hasten the day when it shall be spread

throughout the length and breadth of this great land; and to Thee will we give praise for ever. Amen.

R. W. M.: S. S., what is the last duty of your office?

S. S.: To safely secure all Lodge property that requires to be kept under lock.

R. W. M.: S. W., what is your closing duty?

S. W.: To close this Lodge.

R. W. M.: We are waiting the performance of that duty.

S. W.: As the Sun travels from the East unto the West, and there sets as the close of the day; our labors being now closed, I declare this meeting ended, and command the I. G. to open the W. G. and let the members depart to their homes.

Gives one rap; answered by the R. W. M.

